

DreamXtreme

Core Concept

A darkly humorous, satirical survival game set in a surreal American high desert town, inspired by real experiences navigating healthcare systems and social work.

Players, struggling with chronic back pain and unable to afford treatment, must confront their own prejudices while exploring underground networks for relief.

Through a lens inspired by underground comics and punk culture, players explore intersecting social issues with sharp wit and social commentary. The game draws its inspiration from the absurdity of modern American life, particularly as seen through the eyes of social workers.

Narrative Structure

Two Main Endings with Variations

1. The System Breaker Ending

- Expose and help destroy corrupt healthcare infrastructure
- Variations based on:
 - Community alliances formed
 - Underground networks strengthened
 - Methods used (violent vs. peaceful)
 - Social classes allied with

- Level of system destruction vs. reformation

2. The System Navigator Ending

- Master and transform the broken system from within
- Variations based on:
 - Alternative healthcare networks built
 - Inter-community connections established
 - Reputation among social groups
 - Methods of system manipulation
 - Type of underground economy created

The game emphasizes a variety of characters and paths in between to linear endings with unique versions depending on their social status or what they accumulated.

Depending on their condition overall also, can affect their experience when confronting the different characters and using their resources correctly.

Gender further interconnects with socioeconomic status to influence interactions, alliances, and narrative choices, adding another layer of complexity to social dynamics.

Story Progression

Act 1: The Breaking Point

- Introduction to chronic pain mechanics
- First encounters with healthcare barriers
- Initial prejudices challenged
- Basic underground network exposure

Act 2: The Underground

- Deep dive into social networks
- Building cross-community connections
- Learning to navigate class barriers
- Developing alternative healthcare solutions

Act 3: System Confrontation

- Major choice pathways emerge
- Underground network consolidation
- Final stance on system (break or navigate)
- Community alliance solidification

Visual Style & Tone

Artistic Direction

- Underground comic aesthetic (R. Crumb, Gilbert Shelton influence)
- Exaggerated character designs emphasizing subculture identity
- Surreal desert environments that shift with player perception
- Hand-drawn UI elements with DIY/punk aesthetic
- Psychedelic color palette varying by social scene
- Music-influenced visual effects

Environmental Design

- Buildings that physically twist based on wealth inequality
- Corporate structures that literally consume smaller buildings
- Street layouts that change based on social class

- Weather patterns influenced by community mood
- Desert landscape that warps with pain levels
- Architecture that reflects healthcare barriers

Core Game Systems

Phone System

Core Phone Mechanics

- Battery life serves as "health bar"
- Pain levels affect battery drain
- Signal strength varies by territory
- Apps specific to social classes
- Dead zones in poor areas
- Charging stations as strategic resources

MindBody™ Medical App

- Reality distortion tracker disguised as wellness app
- Corporate-developed "free" health monitoring tool
- Required by insurance for "preventive care tracking"

Health Monitoring Features

- Physical Pain Scale (1-10)
 - Affects movement speed
 - Influences visual distortion
 - Impacts dialog options
 - Tracked by insurance
- Mental State Monitor
 - "Wellness score" tracks reality distortion
 - Low scores increase surreal effects

- High scores attract corporate attention
- Insurance rates tied to maintenance of "healthy" scores
- Drug Interaction System
 - Tracks current substances in system
 - Shows temporary effect timers
 - Lists known side effects
 - Predicts reality distortion changes

Reality Effects Database

- Records encountered reality distortions
- Tracks triggers and patterns
- Shows community "normal" ranges
- Flags "concerning" deviations

Treatment Tracking

Different substances have unique effects:

1. Prescription Medications
 - Highest pain reduction
 - Strongest reality stabilization
 - Most expensive
 - Insurance tracking
 - Corporate side effects
 - Withdrawal risks
2. Street Pharmaceuticals
 - Variable pain relief
 - Unpredictable reality effects
 - Lower cost
 - No tracking

- Street-specific side effects
- Different withdrawal types

3. Alternative Medicines

- Subtle pain management
- Reality "adjustment" rather than stabilization
- Community-based cost
- No official tracking
- Natural side effects
- Minimal withdrawal

Side Effect Examples

- Corporate Meds
 - "Normal" reality becomes suspicious
 - Insurance ads gain hypnotic properties
 - Corporate architecture appears friendly
 - Increased trust in system
- Street Drugs
 - Enhanced pattern recognition
 - Conspiracy theory plausibility
 - Time dilation/compression
 - New social insights
- Alternative Medicine
 - Increased community awareness
 - Enhanced corporate skepticism
 - Reality "flexibility" rather than distortion
 - System pattern recognition

Pain Management

- Chronic back pain as core mechanic
- Pain affects:
 - Movement speed
 - Visual distortion
 - Dialog options
 - Available activities
 - Battery drain rate

Transportation System

Base Movement: Frogger-Style Street Navigation

- Arcade-style street crossing
- Pain-affected movement
- Class-based traffic patterns
- Community reputation effects

Alternative Transport

1. Friend Network Rides

- Free but requires social capital
- Navigation determined by friend's social class access
- Availability features:
 - Must have sufficient phone charge to contact
 - Friend must be "in range" of their usual territory
 - Each friend has specific "comfort zones" they'll drive in
 - Trust level affects willingness to cross territories
 - Can be affected by friend's current story state

2. Friend Types & Limitations:

- Working Class Friend
 - Knows hidden shortcuts
 - Limited to their work schedule
 - Can't enter wealthy areas
 - Shares underground healthcare info
- Elitist Class Friend
 - Access to restricted areas
 - Limited by social obligations
 - Won't enter "dangerous" areas
 - Shares insurance system knowledge
- Resistance Member
 - Knows surveillance-free routes
 - Available during protests
 - Can access multiple territories
 - Shares system weakness info
- Street Level Friend
 - 24/7 availability
 - Knows all neighborhoods
 - Limited by territory conflicts
 - Shares street-level intel

3. Rideshare

- Highest cost
- No battery drain
- Social networking
- Healthcare rumor gathering

4. Bus System

- Fixed routes

- Community hub
- Class territory crossing
- Information exchange

5. Bicycle

- Pain management challenge
- Hidden path access
- Storage requirements
- Community recognition

6. Walking

- Maximum exploration
- Highest pain impact
- Secret area access
- Direct community interaction

Friend Ride Mechanics

Trust Building for Rides:

- Friends become available through story progression
- Trust increases through:
 - Successful interactions
 - Favor exchanges
 - Shared experiences
 - Respecting boundaries

Range & Availability System:

- Each friend has:
 - Home territory radius
 - Work route availability
 - Social space comfort

- No-go zones
- Time-based availability

Phone Integration:

- Must maintain minimum battery to contact
- Signal strength affects call success
- Friend's number must be "unlocked"
- Can track friend locations when shared
- Group chat coordination options

Better Network Mechanics

- Higher-level contacts provide better opportunities, randomly generated per playthrough.
- Better network access reduces travel risk and impacts phone, mental, and physical health.
- Improved networks affect dialog choices and ease mechanics for personality mini-games, creating unique player experiences each playthrough.
- Demo version will showcase a single playthrough, with potential expansions post-demo.

Social Class System & Subcultures

1. Resistance Members

- App: Signal
- Music: Underground punk, protest songs
- Territory: DIY spaces, community centers
- Mini-Game: Surveillance evasion puzzles
- Healthcare Access: Mutual aid networks

- Special Knowledge: System corruption patterns

2. Elitist Class/Libertarian Economists

- App: LinkedIn/Corporate platforms
- Music: Classical, expensive electronic
- Territory: Gated communities, private clinics
- Mini-Game: Market manipulation puzzles
- Healthcare Access: Private systems
- Special Knowledge: Insurance exploits

3. Junkies

- App: Ad-riddled sobriety app
- Music: Lo-fi, street music
- Territory: Street corners, abandoned buildings
- Mini-Game: Rhythm-based survival
- Healthcare Access: Underground clinics
- Special Knowledge: Pain management

4. Gangsters

- App: Tor
- Music: Hard rap, trap
- Territory: Claimed neighborhoods
- Mini-Game: Territory control strategy
- Healthcare Access: Black market
- Special Knowledge: Underground networks

5. Drug Dealers

- App: WhatsApp
- Music: Hip-hop, contemporary trap

- Territory: Mobile spots, safe houses
- Mini-Game: Supply chain management
- Healthcare Access: Alternative medicine
- Special Knowledge: Medicine sources

6. Undercover Cops

- App: Random generated apps
- Music: Generic radio hits
- Territory: Surveillance spots
- Mini-Game: Identity deception
- Healthcare Access: State insurance
- Special Knowledge: System surveillance

7. Illegal Immigrants

- App: Encrypted messaging
- Music: Cultural fusion, homeland music
- Territory: Ethnic enclaves, work sites
- Mini-Game: Document navigation
- Healthcare Access: Community clinics
- Special Knowledge: International medicine

8. Sex Workers

- App: Private review networks
- Music: Pop remixes, club music
- Territory: Strip clubs, massage parlors
- Mini-Game: Client screening
- Healthcare Access: Underground clinics
- Special Knowledge: Cop detection

9. Religious Cult Members

- App: "Spiritual Awakening" platform
- Music: Hypnotic chants, new age
- Territory: Compound outskirts, wellness centers
- Mini-Game: Deprogramming puzzles
- Healthcare Access: Alternative healing
- Special Knowledge: Pain transcendence

Contact System

Core Mechanics

- Unique contacts per social class
- Trust building through understanding
- Cultural appreciation mechanics
- Prejudice affecting information accuracy

Key Contact Types

1. The Corporate Cryptid
 - Lives in hospital ceiling
 - Speaks in insurance code
 - Knows billing secrets
 - Network of medical billing spirits
2. The Conspiracy Truth-Teller
 - Actually correct about healthcare
 - Runs underground pharmacy
 - Lives in bunker of medical records
 - Sees through corporate veils
3. The Enlightened Ex-Junkie
 - Found healing through desert wisdom

- Knows pain management secrets
- Runs underground healing circles
- Can see pain auras

4. The Revolutionary Barista

- Organizes mutual aid through coffee
- Messages in drink orders
- Tracks corporate clinic movements
- Healthcare underground railroad

Trust Building

- Initial prejudices affect information
- Understanding builds connections
- Cultural appreciation unlocks options
- Community reputation systems

World Design

Desert Town Layout

- Divided by class and community
- Key locations:
 - Overworked ER
 - Underground clinics
 - Community centers
 - Corporate facilities
 - Alternative medicine spots
 - Secret meeting locations

Social Environment

- Class barriers as physical obstacles

- Community territories that shift
- Underground networks that evolve
- Healthcare access varying by area

Technical Requirements

Reality Distortion System

- Pain affecting perception
- Class status changing environment
- Trust levels altering information
- Prejudice impacting understanding

Social Network System

- Community reputation tracking
- Trust development metrics
- Resource sharing networks
- Information accuracy variables

Music Integration System

- Soundtrack varying by territory
- Understanding building trust
- Styles affecting gameplay
- Cultural context tracking

Development Priorities

1. Core Systems

- Pain management
- Phone interface
- Basic movement

- Social interaction

2. Social Networks

- Class implementation
- Trust mechanics
- Reputation systems
- Contact network

3. World Building

- Desert environment
- Class territories
- Healthcare facilities
- Underground networks

4. Narrative Integration

- Story progression
- Ending pathways
- Character development
- Satirical elements

Design Philosophy

Medical Underground uses its desert healthcare journey to force players to confront assumptions about different social groups while navigating a broken system. The game rewards curiosity and understanding over judgment, using dark humor and surreal elements to make self-reflection more approachable.

The two main endings provide clear narrative goals while allowing for rich variation in how players reach them. Every social interaction, mini-game, and story beat serves to both

entertain and illuminate real issues through satire and surrealism.

The core message is that survival requires looking past our prejudices to find help in unexpected places, while its mechanics reinforce how systemic issues require community solutions. Through gameplay mechanics that mirror real-world absurdity, players experience both the frustration of broken systems and the hope found in community resilience.